4. Role Questions

What is the role played by the statement that ensuring one is in top shape mentally and physically will help the student?

The court system must remain vigilant of the attempts made by politicians to damage its effectiveness. It has been argued that the separation of powers already keeps a country's judicial system independent and free from political interference. But all political and legal institutions are made by humans, and as such, they are fragile and prone to error.

What is the role played by the statement that the separation of powers keeping a country's judicial system independent and free from political interference?

Let's look at these examples in more detail, starting with the first one:

The first thing I do when approaching Role Questions is to isolate the statement/sentence that the question is asking us about. You can do this either by highlighting or underlining it in the stimulus.

I do this to keep myself focused on the task at hand. If we are making careless mistakes and chose the wrong statement to analyze, then whatever skills we have learned regarding this question type will be for nought.

We will see a drastic increase in the cost of food in the near future. War in the Ukraine has caused a significant disturbance on the global supply of grain and livestock feed. <u>Inflationary pressure on the economy means that prices only have one place to go, and that is up.</u>

What is the role played by the <u>statement about inflationary pressure</u>?

Now with the statement isolated, it's time to turn to the ***second step****: reading the stimulus.*

When reading the stimulus for Role questions, the reading habits are no different from when we are reading the stimulus of a Find the Conclusion Question. We are reading primarily for structure: we are reading the statements one by one, trying to decipher what the author's argument is. We are essentially doing two things: one, categorizing each statement according to their function; and two, finding the conclusion of the argument.

This example is essentially saying that food will get more expensive in the future. This is an opinion and not a fact, so it has the potential to be the example's conclusion. With that in mind we look at the second and third statements to see what their relationship is to the first statement and to each other. The second statement says war has disrupted food supplies, and the third statement says prices are going up due to inflation.

So we have three statements in this example:

1. *Food is going to be more expensive*
2. *Food supply is disrupted*
3. *Inflation is making things cost more*

*Statement 1 is an opinion while Statement 2 and 3 are both facts. As such it appears that both **2 and 3 are supporting 1**. So statement 1 is the conclusion of this example.*

Is there a supporting relationship between statements 2 and 3? Are they both independent premises, or is one of them a premise and the other an intermediate conclusion?

Disrupted supplies will lead to higher costs, inflation also means higher costs. Both are factors contributing to the predicted rise in food prices. Statement 2 and 3 are separate premises each supporting the conclusion, there are no intermediate conclusions in this example!

*Finally, it's time to turn to the **third step** of reading a Role question stimulus: we ask ourselves what is the relationship of the quoted statement to the conclusion of the stimulus?*

It's a premise, independently providing support for the argument's conclusion.

Let's take a look at example 2:

Step 1: isolate the quoted statement within the stimulus

The diligent LSAT student should devote as much time to their emotional and physical wellbeing as to the studying of the LSAT itself. Studying for the LSAT is akin to training for a marathon and requires long term commitment and planning. <u>As a result, ensuring one is in top shape mentally and physically will help the student on their performance.</u>

What is the role played by the statement that <u>ensuring one is in top shape mentally and physically will help the student</u>?

Step 2: examine the stimulus as you would a Find the Conclusion Question, keeping an eye out for the highlighted/underlined statement

It is clear from the example that the second statement is support for the underlined statement. But is the underlined statement the intermediate conclusion or the main conclusion? Consider the relationship between the first statement (The diligent LSAT student should devote as much time to their emotional and physical wellbeing) and the underlined statement (ensuring one is in top shape mentally and physically will help the student on their performance).

Being in good shape mentally and physically will help with performance on the LSAT, therefore we should take care of ourselves mentally and physically. The underlined statement is the intermediate conclusion which supports Statement 1, the conclusion.

Step 3: Double check to make sure we haven't fallen into one of the structural traps test makers love to use to throw us off balance. In other words, make sure we are not confusing an intermediate conclusion for a conclusion, an independent premise for an intermediate conclusion, and that we have correctly differentiated the peripheral information in the stimulus (background information/concession/opposing views) from the core elements of the argument.

Great work, let's look at example 3 before moving on to the more advanced stuff.

Step 1: isolate the quoted statement

The court system must remain vigilant of the attempts made by politicians to damage its effectiveness. It has been argued that <u>the separation of powers already keeps a country's judicial system independent and free from political interference</u>. But all political and legal institutions are made by humans, and as such, they are fragile and prone to error.

What is the role played by the statement that <u>the separation of powers keeping a country's judicial system independent and free from political interference</u>?

Step 2: read the stimulus as you would a Find the Conclusion question, but paying special attention to the underlined statement

The example is arguing for vigilance on the part of judges and the court system and resist undue influence from politicians. That's the conclusion of this argument and is the essence of statement 1. Statement 3, by supporting statement 1, is acting as the premise. That leaves the second statement, the one we are interested in. What is statement 2 saying? Essentially, the separation of powers (institutional judicial independence) is a defense against political interference. Does this support our conclusion that we need to remain vigilant? No, it runs contrary to the spirit of our conclusion and is therefore either a concession or an opposing viewpoint.

A side note for clarification here. Some students end up confusing a "concession" and an "opposing viewpoint." They are similar yet different in one key aspect. An opposing viewpoint is simply what the other party thinks or believes. The author disagrees with it. A concession, on the other hand, is something that the speaker acknowledges, but still holds on to their original view despite it.

As a result, the statement "the separation of powers already keeps a country's judicial system independent and free from political interference" is a view our author makes a note of; they do not acknowledge its merits or validity. Maybe it does to an extent, but it is certainly not enough. So it's an opposing viewpoint with which our author doesn't agree with. On the other hand, had the statement read "granted, the separation of powers keep a country's judicial system independent and free from political interference somewhat," then the statement would be a concession. Because the author has expressed a partial agreement with the statement.

Step 3: reconsider the relationship between the quoted statement and the argument's conclusion, confirm that our reasoning indeed makes sense.

As we have already explained, this statement functions as an opposing viewpoint in the argument.

In summary, how we approach Role questions initially is no different from how we approached Find the Conclusion questions. We have to analyze the stimulus statement by statement, look for the conclusion and premise/intermediate conclusion. We then take the statement that the question is asking as about and ask ourselves, how does it fit into the argument?

Here is a quick list of the habits that will make the process go a lot smoother:

1. *Locate the statement that the question is asking us about. I usually highlight/underline the statement in the question and in the stimulus to provide a constant visual reminder of what it is that I am supposed to be focusing on.*
2. *Read the stimulus as you would a Find the Conclusion question. Categorize each sentence/statement and find what the argument core is. In other words, identify the conclusion, premise, and intermediate conclusion (if there is one).*
3. *Think about the relationship between the quoted statement and the argument's conclusion, what is their relationship?*

Role Question Answer Choices (The Hardest Thing about Role Questions)

While the way in which we read the stimulus of any Role question is similar to how we approach Find the Conclusion questions, the answer choices we are faced with in Role questions are much more difficult. Life would be so simple if all the answer choices were just asking us if the statement in question is a premise or conclusion, but the test makers love to describe a relatively straightforward concept in abstract and vague language in Role question answer choices.

As a result, the successful student should devote the majority of their time and energy to answer choices when approaching Role questions. As you get comfortable with analyzing the structure of the stimulus, it should become second nature to you. I use about 60% of all the time to examine answer choices in Role questions, with the other 40% set aside for reading the question and the stimulus.

The ability to de-abstractify (translating vague and abstract terms that appear in answer choices into their stimulus equivalents) and knowing exactly what they are referring to is one of the most important skills that the advanced student needs to master. If you do not have this ability, often you will end up choosing a wrong answer choice even if you knew what you were looking for. You simply did not understand what the answer choice was trying to say. In other words, advanced students can read through a list of abstract answer choices and know exactly what they are referring to.

Take a look at the following answer choice examples, and see if you can decipher what is it that they are referring to, or even better, try to make up an argument with the components that would function as these answer choices describe:

1. *It is used to illustrate the general principle that the argument presupposes*
2. *It is an illustration of a premise that is used to support the argument's conclusion*
3. *It is used to counter a consideration that might be taken to undermine the argument's conclusion*
4. *It makes an observation that, according to the argument, is insufficient to justify the claim that the argument concludes is false*
5. *It describes a phenomenon for which the argument's conclusion is offered as an explanation*
6. *It is a general principle whose validity the argument questions*
7. *It denies a claim that the argument takes to be assumed in the reasoning it rejects*
8. *It is a claim for which no justification is provided but that is required to establish the argument's main conclusion*
9. *It is a claim for which justification is provided and that, if true, establishes the truth of the argument's main conclusion*
10. *It is what the author's argument purports to explain*
11. *It is a hypothesis that the argument attempts to undermine by calling into question the sufficiency of the evidence*
12. *It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole but is not the only explicitly stated conclusion in the argument*
13. *It is a statement that the argument is intended to support but is not the conclusion of the argument as a whole*
14. *It is a statement for which some evidence is provided and that itself is offered as support for the conclusion of the argument as a whole*
15. *It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole and is supported by another statement for which support is offered*

Yep, that was brutal. You probably had no idea what many of these even meant. Not to worry, let's break them down one by one:

1. It is used to illustrate the general principle that the argument presupposes

*Whenever we are faced with an answer choice that looks super abstract, the first thing to do is to always extract what **keywords** we can to try to make sense of the whole thing. Three words stand out in this answer choice: "illustrate", "general principle", and "presuppose".*

Now certain words have specific meanings within the LSAT. All three of these words appear repeatedly in LR questions and we need to memorize them:

> ***Presuppose:** in daily usage, a presupposition can mean either an assumption or something that is necessary. On the LSAT presuppose simply means "**require**". (It's talking about a necessary condition, something that we will soon cover.)*
>
> ***Illustrate:** an illustration, as it appears in a LR question, is simply referring to an **example/examples***
>
> ***General Principle:** we briefly touched upon the nature of principles on the LSAT in the last chapter, and will do so again further down the road. But for now, just know that a principle is a rule on what we should/shouldn't do; and that it applies to multiple conditions and scenarios.*

For example, "John is always tired in the morning, he should go to bed earlier" is not a principle, we are just talking about one person here. "Those who are tired in the morning should strive to get to bed earlier" is a principle. It's no longer just about John anymore, it is a recommendation for a certain category of people.

So now there are three requirements that must be met if we were to select this hypothetical answer choice as the correct answer: first, the statement in question must be an example; second, behind this example is a principle on what we should or shouldn't do; and lastly, this principle is required in order for the author to advance their argument.

Take a look at this example:

<u>Despite a high paying job, John was extremely stressed out and depressed</u>, so there are intangible things in life that we must pursue to find true happiness.

John's situation is the illustration of a general principle; namely that having a lot of money isn't enough to make you happy. Is this principle required in order for the conclusion to stand? Yes, the conclusion says factors other than money must be considered in order to be happy. The underlined statement satisfies all three requirements and if this was a Role question, this would be the correct answer.

2. It is an illustration of a premise that is used to support the argument's conclusion

*Again, "**illustration**" means example. So we know this answer choice is referring to an example in the stimulus. Furthermore, it is an illustration of a premise. So when examining this answer choice, we must isolate the premise/premises that appear in the argument and ask ourselves, is the quoted statement an example of what the premise is trying to say?*

Here is an example to illustrate what this answer choice is trying to say:

<u>John has been smoking two packs a day since he was sixteen, last week he was diagnosed with lung cancer.</u> Smoking is a direct cause of lung cancer. We must avoid cigarettes at all costs if we want to stay healthy.

What is the premise here? Smoking causes lung cancer. What is the conclusion? Don't smoke. John's case is an illustration of the causal relationship between smoking and lung cancer. Requirement satisfied.

3. It is used to counter a consideration that might be taken to undermine the argument's conclusion

So right away, we should realize that "a consideration that might be taken to undermine the argument's conclusion" is referring to a real or potential counter argument. A counter argument runs contrary to the author's conclusion. If I say "going to college is a great way to enjoy a higher standard of living down the road," but you respond with "but many college graduates have to take years to pay back debt", you are making a counter argument in opposition to me.

Continuing with our example, if I had anticipated your potential objection/counter argument, I can say something along the lines of "college graduates enjoy higher income than their non college counterparts even with the cost of debt factored in." What I'm doing, essentially, is anticipating your potential objection and shutting you down in advance. That's what is meant by countering a consideration that might be taken to undermine the argument's conclusion.

<u>College graduates make more money than they would if they didn't go to college, even if they are paying off student loans plus interest.</u> So going to college is a great way to make more money and enjoy a better life.

Here, the underlined statement is both a premise as well as a pre-emptive strike against a potential objection, namely that graduates end up with so much debt that going to college doesn't make sense.

4. It makes an observation that, according to the argument, is insufficient to justify the claim that the argument concludes is false

A key piece of information we can extract from this answer choice is that there is a claim that the argument concludes is false. In other words, the author of this argument is arguing AGAINST a claim. Someone has made a claim, and the author is saying that claim is false.

So we have two viewpoints in this potential stimulus. The author's argument is directed against an adversary.

Further, we know that the opponent made an observation in support of their view, but the author is saying that observation is not enough to prove anything, and subsequently goes on to argue that the opponent's claim is false.

So in order for this answer choice to be correct, the stimulus must satisfy the following requirements: there must be an opposing view, the author must be arguing against this opposing view and declaring it false. The opponent must have provided an observation as a basis of support for their view, and the author must have made the claim that this observation is not enough to demonstrate the truth of the opponent's view.

Let's go a step further with a concrete example:

John: Celebrities have the biggest smiles in front of the camera, <u>so they must be the happiest people alive</u>.

David: That is not true. Many celebrities suffer from depression and substance abuse. Smiling in front of the camera doesn't mean a thing, they could simply be putting on a show for the audience.

Does the underlined statement fit the requirement for this answer choice? Yes, David is arguing that John's claim is false. David also suggests that the observation John makes in support of his claim is insufficient to justify his claim.

5. It describes a phenomenon for which the argument's conclusion is offered as an explanation

Here is another key term that we must familiarize ourselves with: explanation.

> ***Explanation:*** *on the LSAT, the word "**explanation**" has a very strict and precise meaning, it simply means "**cause**."*

So whenever you see the word "explanation" in an answer choice, check the stimulus for cause - effect reasoning. If it's not there, then this answer would be wrong.

What this answer choice is referring to is something we have seen before. We talked about questions where there is a cause and effect relationship in the argument, but instead of the cause being the premise and the effect being the conclusion, the order is reversed. The author describes a phenomenon and concludes what caused it. See PT43-S3-Q23 in the Find the Conclusion chapter if you had forgotten.

We will reuse our example from the previous chapter:

Smoking is a leading cause of lung cancer, <u>John has lung cancer</u>, therefore he must surely have been a heavy smoker.

John having lung cancer is the phenomenon, the author subsequently concludes that it must be smoking which caused his lung cancer. The cause - effect relationship goes like this: smoking => lung cancer, and the cause/explanation is in fact the conclusion in this example.

6. It is a general principle whose validity the argument questions

Again, this answer choice is referring to a general principle, but it's a general principle that the argument is questioning/attacking. So if we are confronted with this answer choice, we must go back to the stimulus to make sure it satisfies two requirements: one, the quoted statement is indeed a general principle; and two, the author is arguing against the truth of this principle. Here is an example that would match what this answer choice is saying:

It has been said that <u>the best way to approach any situation is to be yourself</u>. But this cannot be true. What if you are a selfish, egotistical or horrible person? Surely we must strive to better ourselves and be the best we can be?

7. It denies a claim that the argument takes to be assumed in the reasoning it rejects

This one is very similar to example 4. The argument is rejecting another person's reasoning. So the author is arguing against someone else here. But are they rejecting that view outright? No, the author does something much more nuanced than that. The author thinks the reasoning used by their opponent has made an assumption, and instead of going after the opponent's argument, our author is going after the opponent's assumption.

So this answer choice is describing a stimulus in which there's two arguments, the author's argument and the opponent's argument. This particular statement is the author rejecting an assumption made by the opponent's argument.

(We will look at the nature of assumptions in a subsequent chapter, as well as in Sufficient and Necessary Assumption question types.)

John: I've studied so hard for the finals, I'm definitely going to ace the exam!

David: <u>Studying hard doesn't guarantee you will do well.</u> The exams are graded on a curve, and everyone else has studied just as hard.

8. It is a claim for which no justification is provided but that is required to establish the argument's main conclusion

There are two important pieces of information in this answer choice that can help us determine whether it's the correct answer. First, it is "required" to establish the argument's main conclusion. That means it's necessary in order for the main conclusion to be valid. So there's no way this answer choice is talking about the conclusion itself, it's therefore either a premise or an intermediate conclusion.

Second, the answer choice says it's a claim for which no justification is provided. Remember what we said about how to differentiate between premises and intermediate conclusions in the previous chapter? Premises support the conclusion but do not have any other statements supporting them, whereas intermediate conclusions both support the conclusion and are supported by premises. So when we have a statement which supports the conclusion but is not supported by others, it can only mean one thing: we are talking about a premise here.

So we are essentially talking about a premise that is required to establish the truth of the conclusion. In other words, if the premise was untrue, the conclusion would not stand. Take a look at the following example for more clarity:

I found an Olympic gold medal in the swim team locker room. It must have originally belonged to John. John is always losing things and <u>he participated in the Olympics</u>.

John's participation in the Olympics is a requirement for the example's conclusion to stand. In order for John to be the original owner of the medal, he MUST have been a participant at least.

John's participation in the Olympics is also a premise that supports the example argument's conclusion.

9. It is a claim for which justification is provided and that, if true, establishes the truth of the argument's main conclusion

Very similar to the example listed above, but with two important caveats. This answer choice HAS justification provided, while supporting the main conclusion, so it's an intermediate conclusion. It also ***guarantees/establishes*** *the truth of the conclusion.*

All practicing lawyers must have passed the bar. John is a partner at a prestigious law firm and therefore <u>he is a practicing lawyer</u>, so he must have passed the bar.

John being a practicing lawyer is supported by the fact that he is a partner at a law firm. This satisfies the intermediate conclusion requirement. Does John being a practicing lawyer establish the fact that he has passed the bar? Yes, it is mentioned in the first statement/premise that all practicing lawyers must have passed the bar.

10. It is what the author's argument purports to explain

This is identical to example 5: the author describes an effect/result/phenomenon, and argues for a specific cause.

11. It is a hypothesis that the argument attempts to undermine by calling into question the sufficiency of the evidence

What is a hypothesis? In science, a hypothesis is offered by scientists to try to explain a phenomenon in the physical world or universe. Why did different types of birds have physical features that are adapted to their physical environments? Darwin hypothesized that it is due to the fact that species can change over time, adapting to their environments via physical modifications generation after generation. Darwin came up with a hypothesis, which today we know as The Theory of Evolution, that has been supported by evidence gathered both by him and subsequent scientists. In other words, a hypothesis is simply a posited causal explanation of a phenomenon, explaining WHY something is the way it is.

On the LSAT, the word "hypothesis" can be understood as a "potential explanation/potential causation"; it usually appears in science/medicine themed LR stimuli.

So what is this answer choice saying? The argument is attempting to undermine this hypothesis. It does so by saying that the evidence out there is not enough to support such a hypothesis. So when we are going through answer choices and come to this, we must make sure that there is a hypothesis present in the stimulus (the quoted statement being that hypothesis), the author is challenging this hypothesis, and the author does so by suggesting that the available evidence is not enough to support this hypothesis.

12. It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole but is not the only explicitly stated conclusion in the argument

Two pieces of key information here. The first is straightforward: we are talking about the main conclusion here. But note that it "is not the only explicitly stated conclusion in the argument". That can only mean one thing: we have an intermediate conclusion in the argument as well. So if confronted with this answer choice, make sure that one, the statement we are talking about is in fact the main conclusion of the argument; and two, the argument contains a separate intermediate conclusion.

13. It is a statement that the argument is intended to support but is not the conclusion of the argument as a whole

Something that is supported by the argument but is not the main conclusion, that's an intermediate conclusion we are talking about here.

14. It is a statement for which some evidence is provided and that itself is offered as support for the conclusion of the argument as a whole

Same as above. The statement in question is supported by support, and supports the main conclusion. This is also the intermediate conclusion.

15. It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole and is supported by another statement for which support is offered

Same as example 12: the statement referred to by the answer choice is the main conclusion, and is supported by another statement for which support is offered. So the main conclusion is supported by an intermediate conclusion. When faced with an answer choice like this, make sure it is indeed the main conclusion that the question is asking us to analyze, and make sure the argument contains an intermediate conclusion.

A Selection of the Hardest Role Questions

Take a look at the following questions. Try to go through the questions practicing the skills developed earlier in the chapter. Try to follow the steps as I have outlined above, paying special attention to the answer choices! Do the questions first before looking at my explanations!

Again, if you find yourself struggling with some of the questions, don't worry too much about timing. Use the opportunity to develop a systematic approach to these types of questions, fill in knowledge gaps, and familiarize yourself with how to decipher an abstract answer choice. For the advanced test taker, try to aim for under 3 minutes per question, 2 minutes per question is really good, granted that you are getting them correct and following the steps.

Structurally analyzing the stimulus is the first step to successfully tackling Role questions. In fact, complicated arguments with multiple premises, intermediate conclusions, and background information is the most common characteristic of harder Role questions.

Difficult Trait #1: Make sure you are clearly categorizing each statement that appears in the stimulus and argument as you are reading it. Don't confuse the intermediate conclusion for the main conclusion.

C
<u>PT34 S3 Q14</u>

People's political behavior frequently does not match their rhetoric. Although many complain about government intervention in their lives, they tend not to re-elect inactive politicians. But a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement affects voters' lives; Thus, voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the argument by the claim that people tend not to re-elect inactive politicians?

A. It describes a phenomenon for which the argument's conclusion is offered as an explanation

B. It is a premise offered in support of the conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent

C. It is offered as an example of how a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement interferes with voters' lives

D. It is a generalization based on the claim that people complain about government intervention in their lives

E. It is cited as evidence that people's behavior never matches their political beliefs

Let's break this question down step by step:

First things first, let's make a note of what is it exactly that we are going to analyze in this question:

People's political behavior frequently does not match their rhetoric. Although many complain about government intervention in their lives, <u>they tend not to re-elect inactive politicians</u>. But a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement affects voters' lives. Thus, voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent.

Which one of the following most accurately describes the role played in the argument by the claim that <u>people tend not to re-elect inactive politicians</u>?

So it's the second half of the second statement that we are concerned with, let's now break down the stimulus structurally.

Look at this stimulus, what is the argument that the author is trying to make? What is their conclusion, and what premises do they use to support that conclusion?

Statement 1: People's political behavior frequently does not match their rhetoric

This can be an opinion of the authors, or it can be an observation. At this point it can either be used for support or supported by another statement. Let's keep on reading and try to situate this statement when we have more information.

Statement 2: Although many complain about government intervention in their lives, <u>they tend not to re-elect inactive politicians</u>

This statement seems like a further development of the first statement. It offers more details. So people say they want governments to leave them alone, but they don't like politicians who don't do anything. (In other words, politicians who actually do leave them alone don't get any support.)

It seems to me that statement 1 is a summary of what statement 2 is actually describing. Statement 2 seems like a premise at the moment, maybe statement 1 is the conclusion or intermediate conclusion. Let's keep on going.

Statement 3: But a politician's activity consists largely in the passage of laws whose enforcement affects voters' lives

Stop and think. How does this piece of information tie in with what we have read and gathered previously? In statement 2 we said that voters say they don't like interference, but don't vote for inactive politicians. This statement is saying what political activities are; in other words, what active politicians do. Active politicians interfere in voters' lives. Inactive politicians don't get the votes, active ones do. So voters say they don't want interference but will go on to vote for interfering politicians.

Statement 2 and 3 are definitely premises. Statement 1 seems like the conclusion so far, let's take a look at the last sentence.

Statement 4: Thus, voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent

How the last statement is presented should already be familiar to the discerning student. It's the last statement and begins with "thus". It could signify the actual conclusion of the argument, but we must remember that often the test makers will present an intermediate conclusion this way. So always make sure. Here it is the intermediate conclusion, while the first statement is in fact the conclusion. Here is the argument in simplified form:

Premise 1: People want governments to leave them alone, but they don't vote for politicians who are inactive. (Assumption: It's the active politicians who get the votes)

Premise 2: Active politicians don't leave people alone.

Intermediate Conclusion: People end up voting for politicians that do things they don't like (interference).

Conclusion: What people say (leave me alone!) don't match what they do (vote for interfering politicians).

Now let's think about the relationship between the underlined statement and the conclusion, and how the underlined statement functions in the author's argument.

Before approaching the answer choices, we have come to an understanding that the statement in question is a premise, the argument contains two premises, an intermediate conclusion, and a main conclusion.

Now for the hard part, differentiating between answer choices:

A. It describes a phenomenon for which the argument's conclusion is offered as an explanation

We have seen this kind of structure before, once in the previous chapter on Find the Conclusion questions, and again in the exercise earlier in the chapter. A phenomenon is presented, and a cause is provided. Why is John grumpy? It's because he didn't have his morning coffee. Why is David late? Because his car broke down. The statement in question is not a phenomenon that the conclusion provides the cause for. If the argument in the stimulus read like this, then A would be the correct answer:

Voters tend not to re-elect inactive politicians. This is because people forget about politicians who haven't done anything and people vote for those that have made a strong impression.

Let's keep on going.

B. It is a premise offered in support of the conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent

(Handwritten note circling "the conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent" pointing to the margin: "conclusion choice don't run from convoluted name")

Looks good on a first pass: it is indeed a premise, and it is supporting the (intermediate) conclusion that voters often re-elect politicians whose behavior they resent. But the premise is calling the intermediate conclusion an conclusion, is that grounds for elimination?

Remember this answer choice from our exercise earlier?

It is the conclusion of the argument as a whole but is not the only explicitly stated conclusion in the argument